

RARE

1. Passage anchor

> “She spoke in a calm, confident way, and she had this ****rare ability**** to make difficult ideas sound much less frightening.”

Passage meaning

****rare**** = unusual because very few people have it or because it does not happen often

****難得的；少見的；罕見的****

Here:

> ****a rare ability****

= ****一種很難得的能力****

The speaker means Ms. Lau had an unusually valuable skill: making difficult ideas feel much easier and less intimidating.

Practice

1. She has a ****rare ability**** to explain complex ideas simply.
她有一種****很難得的能力****，能把複雜概念解釋得很簡單。
2. Patience combined with sharp judgment is a ****rare quality****.
耐心加上敏銳判斷力是一種****少見的特質****。

Core meanings of RARE

2. rare — uncommon / not often found

= not common; existing, happening, or found only occasionally

****罕見的；少見的；不常見的****

Examples

1. Snow is ****rare**** in this area.
這個地區很少下雪；下雪很****罕見****。
2. It is ****rare**** to find someone with that combination of skills.
很少能找到具備那種能力組合的人。

This is the central meaning.

3. rare event / occurrence

= something that happens infrequently

****罕見事件；少見情況****

Examples

1. Such accidents are extremely ****rare****.

這類事故非常****罕見****。

2. A total solar eclipse is a relatively ****rare event**** in any one location.

對任何單一地點而言，日全食都是相對****罕見的事件****。

Unusual person / quality

4. rare quality / ability / talent

= an unusual and valuable quality or ability that few people possess

****難得的特質 / 能力 / 天分****

This is the exact passage branch.

Examples

1. She has a ****rare talent**** for making people feel comfortable.

她有一種****難得的天分****，能讓人感到自在。

2. His combination of humility and confidence is ****rare****.

他那種謙遜與自信並存的特質很****少見****。

5. rare person / individual

= someone with unusual or exceptional qualities

****難得的人；少見的人****

Examples

1. She is a ****rare teacher**** who can challenge students without making them feel small.

她是一位**很難得的老師**，既能挑戰學生，又不會讓他們感到渺小。

2. He is one of those **rare people** who listens carefully before speaking.
他是那種很**少見的人**，總會先仔細聽完才說話。

Scarce / difficult to obtain

6. rare — scarce or hard to find

= existing in very small quantities and therefore difficult to obtain

稀有的；稀少的

Examples

1. The museum contains several **rare books**.

這間博物館收藏了幾本**珍稀書籍**。

2. The animal is becoming increasingly **rare**.

這種動物正變得愈來愈**稀少**。

This sense often applies to:

- * species
- * books
- * minerals
- * objects
- * materials

7. rare species

= species with very small populations or limited distribution

稀有物種；罕見物種

Examples

1. The island is home to several **rare species**.

這座島是幾種**稀有物種**的棲息地。

2. Conservationists are trying to protect a **rare bird species**.

保育人士正努力保護一種**稀有鳥類**。

8. rare book / object

= old, unusual, valuable, or difficult-to-find item

珍本；稀有物件

Examples

1. The library has a collection of **rare books**.
圖書館收藏了一批**珍本書籍**。
2. Collectors paid a high price for the **rare object**.
收藏家為那件**稀有物件**付了高價。

Valuable because uncommon

9. rare — exceptional / unusually good

= unusual in a positive way because the quality is uncommon

難得的；非凡的

Examples

1. She showed **rare courage**.
她展現了**難得的勇氣**。
2. He has a **rare combination of intelligence and humility**.
他兼具智慧和謙遜，這種組合非常**難得**。

This often sounds more appreciative than simply “uncommon.”

Meat cooking

10. rare — lightly cooked, especially meat

= cooked only a little, so the inside remains red

三分熟的；偏生的

Examples

1. I'd like my steak **rare**.
我的牛排要**三分熟**。

2. The meat was too **rare** for me.

這塊肉對我來說太**生**了。

This is a completely distinct adjective sense.

11. medium-rare

= cooked slightly more than rare, but still red/pink inside

三至五分熟；偏三分熟

Examples

1. I usually order steak **medium-rare**.

我通常點**三至五分熟**的牛排。

2. The chef recommends serving it **medium-rare**.

主廚建議把它做到**三至五分熟**。

Rare as adverbial-like complement in food orders

12. cook / serve something rare

= cook meat lightly

把肉煮得偏生 / 三分熟

Examples

1. Please cook the steak **rare**.

請把牛排煎成**三分熟**。

2. This cut is often served **rare**.

這個部位通常會以**偏生的熟度**上桌。

Related forms

13. rarely

= not often

很少；不常

Examples

1. She **rarely** gets angry.

她**很少**生氣。

2. We **rarely** see snow here.

我們這裡**很少**下雪。

Important relation:

* **rare** = adjective

* **rarely** = adverb

14. rarity

= state of being rare; or a rare thing/person

罕見；稀有；罕見之物

Examples

1. Snow is a **rarity** in this region.

下雪在這個地區是一件**罕見的事**。

2. Genuine examples of this kind are a **rarity**.

真正這一類的例子非常**少見**。

15. rarefied

This is historically related but has developed separate meanings, especially:

* thin / less dense, especially air → **稀薄的**

* exclusive / intellectually elevated → **高深的；小圈子的**

Because it is no longer a straightforward learner-family extension of **rare**, it should be treated separately if needed.

High-value collocations

16. extremely / exceptionally rare

= very uncommon

****極其罕見的****

Examples

1. This condition is ****extremely rare****.

這種情況****極其罕見****。

2. Such a combination is ****exceptionally rare****.

這種組合****極為少見****。

17. relatively rare

= uncommon, but not extremely so

****相對少見的****

Examples

1. This mistake is ****relatively rare****.

這種錯誤****相對少見****。

2. The species is ****relatively rare**** in urban areas.

這個物種在城市地區****相對少見****。

18. increasingly rare

= becoming less and less common

****愈來愈少見的****

Examples

1. Handwritten letters are becoming ****increasingly rare****.

手寫信正變得****愈來愈少見****。

2. This type of habitat is ****increasingly rare****.

這類棲息地正變得****愈來愈稀少****。

19. rare opportunity

= unusual chance that does not arise often

****難得的機會****

Examples

1. This is a ****rare opportunity**** to work with experts in the field.

這是一個與該領域專家合作的****難得機會****。

2. She was given a ****rare opportunity**** to study abroad.

她得到了一個出國留學的****難得機會****。

20. rare occasion

= event or situation that occurs infrequently

****難得的場合；少有的情況****

Examples

1. On the ****rare occasion**** that he is late, he always apologizes.

在他****少有遲到的情況下****，他總會道歉。

2. It was a ****rare occasion**** when the whole family was together.

那是一個全家人難得齊聚的****少有場合****。

Grammar pattern

21. it is rare for someone to do something

= it does not often happen that someone does something

****某人做某事很少見****

Examples

1. It is ****rare for her to lose patience****.

她失去耐性是很****少見的****。

2. It is ****rare for the class to be completely silent****.

全班完全安靜是很****少見的****。

22. it is rare to do something

= doing something is uncommon

****做某事很少見****

Examples

1. It is ****rare to find such a patient teacher****.

找到這麼有耐心的老師很****難得****。

2. It is ****rare to see this animal in the wild****.

在野外看到這種動物很****罕見****。

Key contrasts

23. rare vs uncommon

****rare****

= very infrequent or found in small numbers

****罕見的；稀有的****

****uncommon****

= not common, but often weaker and more neutral

****不常見的；少見的****

Compare:

> a ****rare disease****

> 罕見疾病

> an ****uncommon spelling****

> 不常見的拼法

There is substantial overlap.

24. rare vs unusual

****unusual****

= different from what is normal, expected, or typical

****不尋常的****

****rare****

= occurring or existing infrequently

****少見的****

Something can be:

* unusual but not rare

* rare but not especially strange

Compare:

> It is ****unusual**** for him to be quiet.

> 他今天這麼安靜很不尋常。

> This bird is ****rare**** in this region.

> 這種鳥在這個地區很罕見。

25. rare vs scarce

****rare****

= uncommon or existing in small numbers

****scarce****

= insufficient in quantity relative to need or demand

****短缺的；稀缺的****

Compare:

> a ****rare species****

> 稀有物種

> clean water is ****scarce****

> 乾淨水源短缺

****Scarce**** emphasizes shortage; ****rare**** emphasizes uncommonness.

26. rare vs unique

****unique****

= one of a kind or unlike anything else

****獨一無二的****

****rare****

= uncommon, but more than one may exist

Compare:

> a **rare talent**

> 少見的天分

> a **unique fingerprint**

> 獨一無二的指紋

Do not automatically use **unique** simply to mean “very rare.”

27. rare vs exceptional

exceptional

= unusually good or far above normal

傑出的 ; 非凡的

rare

= uncommon; may or may not be good

Compare:

> a **rare disease**

> 罕見疾病

> an **exceptional teacher**

> 非常傑出的老師

In:

> a rare ability

the meaning is positive because the ability is both uncommon and valuable.

28. rare vs seldom / rarely

rare

= adjective

> a **rare event**

rarely / seldom

= adverbs

> It ****rarely happens****.

Do not say:

> *It rare happens.* ✗

Meaning map

The central concept of ****rare**** is:

****not commonly found or experienced****

From this develop:

Frequency

a rare event

→ ****罕見事件****

Valuable personal quality

rare ability

→ ****難得能力****

Scarcity

rare species

→ ****稀有物種****

Opportunity

rare opportunity

→ ****難得機會****

A completely separate culinary branch is:

Meat

rare steak

→ ****三分熟 / 偏生****

The passage uses the positive-uncommon quality sense:

****few people possess this ability****

→ ****a rare ability****

→ ****很難得的能力****

MCQ-ready master list

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
rare — uncommon	很少出現、存在或被發現的；罕見的 / 少見的
rare event/occurrence	發生頻率非常低的事件 / 情況
rare quality/ability/talent	很少有人具備，因此顯得難得或珍貴的特質 / 能力 / 天分
rare person	因具有少見而可貴特質而顯得很難得的人
rare — scarce object/species	數量很少、難以找到的；稀有的
rare species	數量少或分布有限的稀有物種
rare book/object	因數量少、年代、價值等原因而難得一見的珍稀物品
rare opportunity	不常出現、值得把握的難得機會
rare occasion	很少出現的場合或情況
rare — meat	肉只稍微煮熟、中心仍偏紅；三分熟 / 偏生
medium-rare	比 rare 稍熟、中心仍明顯粉紅或偏紅；三至五分熟
rarely	某事發生頻率低；很少 / 不常
rarity	罕見或稀有的狀態；也可指罕見的人 / 事物
it is rare for...	某人做某事的情況很少發生
it is rare to...	做某事是很少見 / 難得的

Passage recap

> “...she had this ****rare ability**** to make difficult ideas sound much less frightening.”

Here:

****rare**** = ****uncommon and unusually valuable because few people have that ability****

Best Traditional Chinese:

* ****難得的****

* ****少見的****

* ****罕有的****

Natural contextual translation:

****她有一種很難得的能力，就是能把困難的概念講得沒那麼可怕。****

Passage MCQ-ready meaning

rare in **“rare ability”**

= **unusual because very few people possess it**

難得的；少見的；罕見的

It does not mean the food sense:

> **rare steak**

> → **三分熟 / 偏生的牛排**

The passage meaning is specifically:

uncommon + valuable.